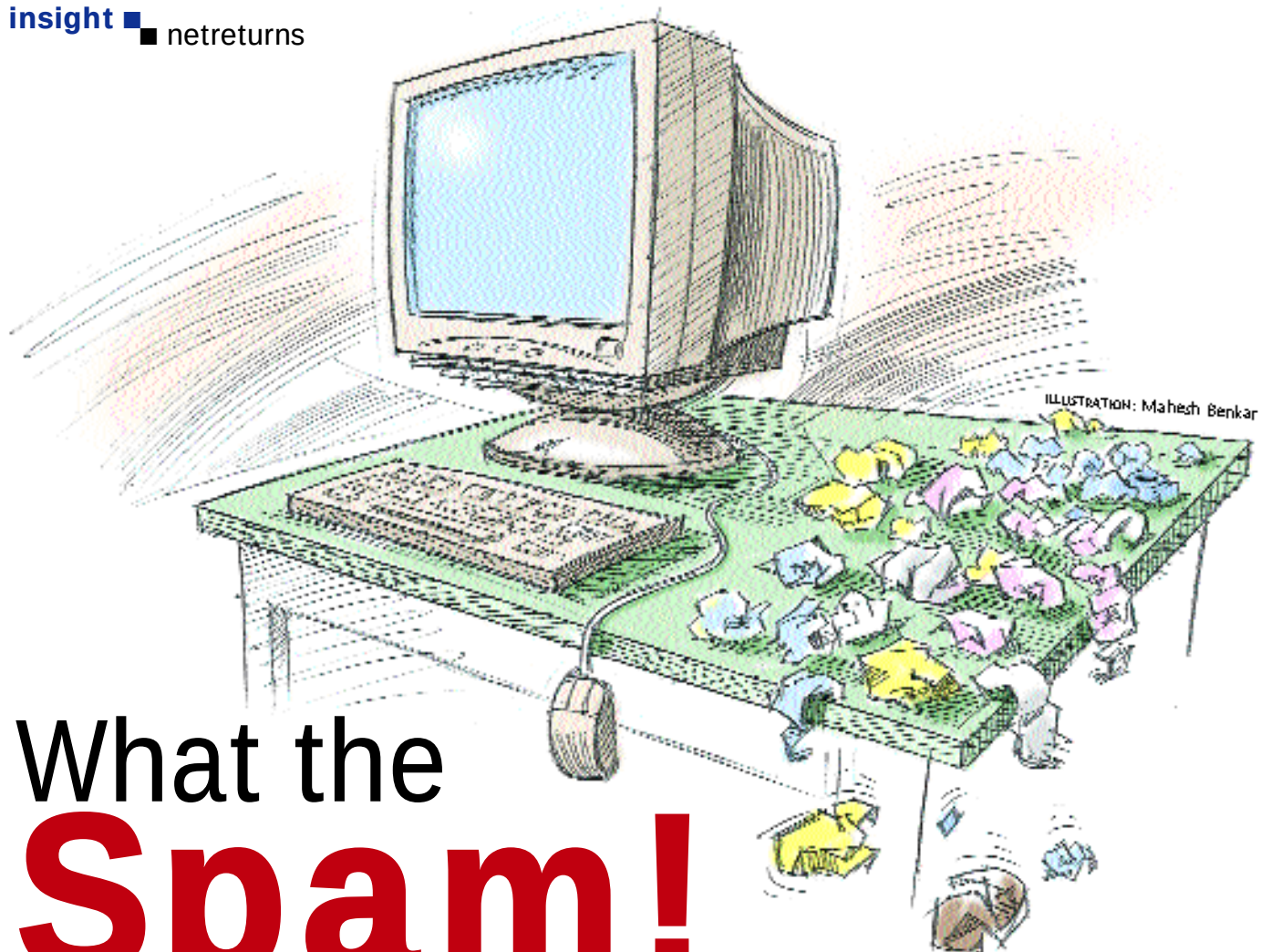


What the Spam!



Spam, in all its forms, is not a welcome sight in your mailbox. Here's how you throw the gauntlet back on its face!

Anyone with an e-mail ID, and using it regularly to send and receive e-mails, to authenticate oneself to various service Web sites and subscribe to newsletters related to your areas of interest, receives spam. Whether you choose to do anything about it is a different matter—some just ignore it, some delete it, and others employ software tools to block or filter spam.

What is Spam

Spam, refers to unsolicited commercial, or bulk e-mail that floods the Internet with many copies of the same message, in an attempt to force messages on people who would otherwise choose not to receive it. Be it that superb free phone offer or the ardent plea for money for a charitable cause—these are all classic examples of how spam can draw your attention. Of

course, the usual tricks of newsletters and subscriptions to pornographic Web sites are faithfully employed.

The simplest ways for a spammer to obtain a large number of e-mail addresses is to buy them in bulk from companies, and by using automated scripts called spambots that parse Web pages and newsgroups, and look for strings of characters that resemble e-mail addresses. These spambots harvest whatever e-mail addresses they can find and make them available to the spammer, or even send out e-mails directly. Spammers also use name generation programs to generate e-mail addresses to send bulk e-mail, even though most of these may not be valid. Spammers also procure e-mail addresses from mailing lists and from people themselves, when they reply to spam asking for removal.

Reporting spam

There are a lot of ways to report spam. The Coalition Against Unsolicited Commercial E-mail (CAUCE) is an ad hoc, voluntary organization, created by Netizens to advocate for a legislative solution to the problem of spam. The Indian chapter of CAUCE (www.india.cauce.org) is dedicated to nipping the spam problem while it is still a manageable issue before it snowballs into a bigger problem.

The basic step to fight spam is to report it to the spammer's service provider. To find out where the spam came from, you have to use the headers of the e-mail. This is a slightly complicated process. However, you can use www.spamcop.net, a Web site that reports spam on your behalf. All you need to do is to register free with the Web site, and SpamCop will send an appropriate e-mail on your behalf to the